

sa

ISSUE 2 2021

Homeschooling

LIVING & LEARNING – TOGETHER

WIN! SEE PAGE 20



5 Great ideas
for parents to
destress

Nutrients of knowledge
to help build and
bolster better brains

Tips on how to have
'that Web' convo with
your tweens and teens

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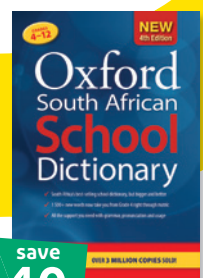
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save
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Lots of lovely reads for children of all ages and languages.



Ed's note

Hello and welcome to our second issue of *SA Homeschooling*.

For many of us, 2020 was a year of fears, worries, challenges and rethinking. We've learnt to live with the pandemic and through this experience, we've had to adapt and grow in ways we'd never imagined.

One of my learning curves has been my growing understanding of the lives of homeschooling families; of your courage and creativity, your great love for your children and your determination to offer them the best possible educational experience. It hasn't been easy, has it? You've had to contend with confusing legislation; difficult choices regarding study programmes; turning your homes into schoolrooms and holiday spaces in which to relax, explore and play when the world out there isn't always safe.

We here at *SA Homeschooling* honour you for what you've accomplished and will strive to support you throughout 2021 in your – and our – quest for contentment, success and knowledge.

Happy reading, happy learning!

Shelagh

Editor

Contributors



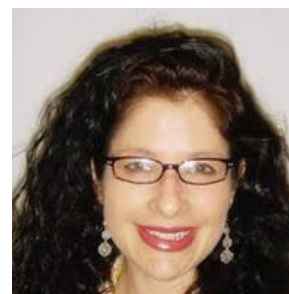
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Marian is a remedial therapist and a mom with a special interest in early reading development and teaching readers from ages five to nine online and in person. In addition to reading lessons through Raising Readers, she offers homeschooling parent talks, workshops and multi-sensory literacy kits to help you raise your child to read.

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Pam is a clinical psychologist, forensic psychologist, leadership development consultant, parent/child educator and the mother of two boys, aged 13 and 11. She's the co-founder of KLIKD and co-author of *Your Teen Unleashed!*, a guide to how best to show up for your teen as they negotiate the online world.



www.klikd.co.za | www.facebook.com/KlikdSA



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www.facebook.com/CapeHomeEducators
www.facebook.com/The-South-African-National-Home-Schooling-Association-104361004707947/

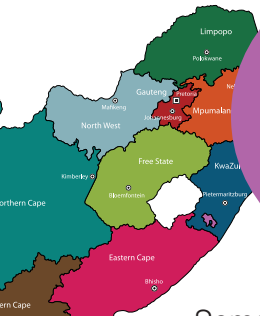


Your stationery checklist

Running out of paper or highlighters is a pain at the best of times. During these days, it's even more important to have all these bits and pieces to hand so that you don't have to dash to the shops or place yet another online order. We recommend having most of these items at the ready – depending on the ages and interests of your children.



'By
child in the
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cupboard a
are giving t
well as a
'working' en
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sense of res
who they are
– www.



REFERENCE MATERIALS

Sometimes a book beats the Internet (particularly during loadshedding) and teaching your children to 'look it up' is invaluable for problem-solving, referencing and a love of learning.

UK English dictionary

South African English dictionary

Other local language/
English dictionaries

A thesaurus (where words are listed according to synonyms and related concepts)

An up-to-date map of the world

An up-to-date map
of South Africa

A map of your regions



CONSUMABLES – AND SPARES

Printer paper

Printer cartridge

Pens and pencils

Eraser and sharpener

Notebooks (spiral ones are great for quick note-taking)

Workbooks

Graph paper

Squared exercise
books for arithmetic

Sellotape

Stick glue



CRAFTS

Play dough, plasticine
and modelling clay

Clear glue

Wallpaper paste

Super glue

Bits and pieces of fabric,
decorations, newspaper and
coloured paper for collages
and papier-mâché

Scissors, modelling tools
and craft knives



HARDWARE ESSENTIALS

A desktop or laptop computer

An external hard drive for
extra back-up

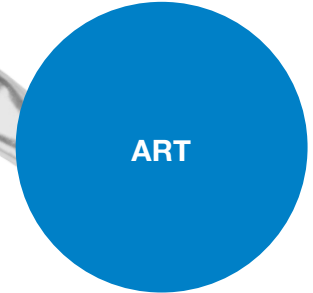
A printer-scanner

A good storage system with files
and folders, binders and dividers

A paper punch

A tray for re-usable paper

A pinboard and pins



ART

Crayons, Kokis and markers

Sketch pencils/pens

Sketch pad

Blank poster paper

Canvas frames

Water colour paints

Poster paints

Acrylics and/or oil paints

An easel or stand

Blackboard and different-
coloured chalk

TIP

involving your
process of building
locking the stationery
and the classroom, you
them responsibility as
authority over their
environment. This begins
s of independence, a
responsibility and pride in
e and the work they do.'

statesman.co.za/



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**BRING OUT THE
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schooling experience
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your child's unique
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- Age-appropriate life coaching
- Flexible learning allowing self-paced progression
- Digital mastery
- Flexible learning allowing self-paced progression
- An emphasis on the habits of mind and skills your child will need to thrive in a knowledge-based economy

GRADES

R – 9

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LEARN WITHOUT LIMITS

Brought to you by ADvTECH, Africa's largest private education provider. ADvTECH's Schools division comprises of school brands such as Crawford International School, TrinityHouse Schools, Maragon, Abbots College and the Pinnacle group of schools.

We've got *mail*

What have I learnt about myself during homeschooling? I guess I've learnt that I'm not as perfectly patient as I first thought!

Before I became a mom, I always thought of myself as a really patient person. I always told myself I'd never be like my own mother. I'd have the greatest patience with my child. Then Covid-19 hit and we all had to be home. Schools were closed and most people had to work from home, with homeschooling becoming the new norm. I thought: 'Oh, great – I can do this! How hard can it be to get a four-year-old to do distance learning?'

Yeah, right. Getting a four-year-old to sit down and concentrate, for even a minute, takes tons of patience. I guess the lesson learnt is that Covid-19 gave me the opportunity to grow in this area.

Bavina

Send your letters to

shelagh@isikhova.co.za and you could win one of four CNA gift vouchers worth R500!

Can I talk about housework? I worked half-days as a receptionist and used to do the housework before nine-year-old Jarred and seven-year-old Ellie got back from school. Then suddenly there was no school and I had to figure out how to set up a homeschool, still go to work and keep a neat house. Ha ha!

We did work it out, mostly. My hubby can work from home, so he does the washing and the like

in the morning while supervising the kids in their Zoom calls (we hate those!) and schoolwork. Then I come home, clean up a bit and take care of the kids while my hubby goes to the office.

We still haven't got it right, but one thing we agree on is that our kids have learnt much more at home, so we're going to carry on homeschooling even after Covid-19.

Primrose



I'm a single dad wanting to start homeschooling my 11-year-old son. Are there support groups available for single parents which could help me move in this direction? I'd really like to see an article about homeschooling for single parents.

Saul

I'm a homeschooling mom with a full-time job and have been working from home since March 2020. When Covid-19 hit, I took the plunge, removed my kids from mainstream schools and started homeschooling. I was really struggling to balance it all and spent most days feeling overwhelmed and worried about my decision to homeschool. A fellow mom shared your magazine with me online and I just want to thank you for providing

a publication for us newbies to follow. The homeschool community has been very welcoming and I'm thrilled to have such an insightful magazine to help guide me through the process.

Bernice



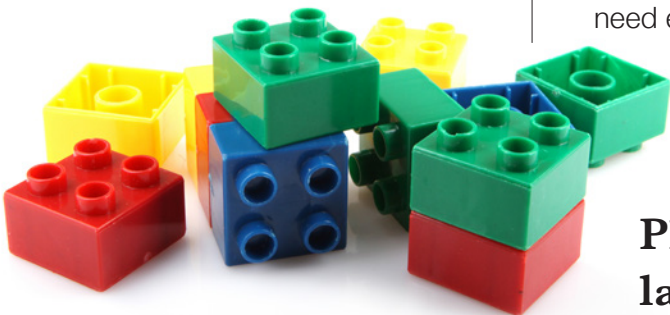
In the beginning...

Learning to read begins well before the age of five or six. In fact, it all begins when children start hearing sounds and words. Remedial therapist **Marian Bailey** explains this fascinating process

The ability to hear, identify and manipulate the sounds in spoken language has proved to help young children become better readers. Even before they learn to read and identify the letters of the alphabet, children can say the sounds they hear in spoken language. When they can hear the sounds in a word, and play with those sounds in their head, identifying where the sounds occur in the word, they're getting ready to read.

Phonological awareness is the foundation on which all other

reading skills are built. Without a strong foundation, literacy gaps can emerge and this is even truer for children with reading and spelling challenges, such as dyslexia. Building solid phonological awareness skills daily is the best way to ensure a strong reading foundation. The best part is that developing these skills can be engaging and fun and you don't need expensive equipment.



‘There’s a difference between phonological awareness and phonics. Phonological awareness refers to oral language, while phonics refers to print.’



There's a difference between phonological awareness and phonics. Phonological awareness refers to oral language, while phonics refers to print. Think of

CLAP CLAP it like this: phonological awareness activities can be done with your eyes shut! Phonic activities require the letters and words in print, such as on flash cards or in books.

Phonological awareness is a broad skill that includes identifying and manipulating units of oral language such as words, syllables, onsets (the initial consonant in a word) and rimes (the vowel and



consonant that follow the onset). Phonemic awareness refers to the specific ability to focus on and manipulate individual sounds (phonemes) in spoken words.

Teaching phonological awareness should be explicit and systematic, starting from big units, such as sentences and compound words, and moving to small ones such as phonemes – the individual sounds in a word. Teach children that the sentences and words we speak can be taken apart.

Building phonological awareness skills will prepare your young child's brain to read the printed word. That includes the following skills: rhyming, alliteration and initial sounds in words, breaking sentences apart into words, breaking words into syllables, breaking compound words apart and putting them back together, onsets, rimes and phonemes.

How to do it

The best way to practise and teach phonological awareness is by using movement and movable objects such as counters, play dough, Lego, wooden blocks and animal pictures.

Here are a few examples of phonological awareness activities. Keep practice fun and short. Five minutes a day doing these activities at the breakfast table, in the car, at the pool or before reading time will build a better reading brain.



Activity 1: Sentence segmentation. Say a sentence to your child ('I love to eat apples') and ask your child to say the sentence back to you slowly, counting each word on their fingers. Start with simple three- or four-word sentences and, as your child practises this skill, increase the number of words. Sentence length will also depend on the age of your child.

Activity 2: Say a word to your child and ask them whether it's a short word or a long one. Use your hands to show the size. Continue using short one-syllable ('cat'), medium two-syllable ('party') and long three- or more-syllable ('crocodile', 'helicopter') words. *Helpful hint:* A syllable must contain a vowel.

Activity 3: Clap syllables in words. You can also call a syllable a beat ('croc-o-dile', 'par-ty').

Activity 4: Rhyme. Show a picture of a dog and ask your child what rhymes with 'dog'. Continue using pictures of familiar animals and objects.



Activity 5: Compound words.
Use Lego blocks to put two words together to make a new word ('cupcake', 'snowflake', 'sunset') and to pull a compound word apart to form two individual words.

Activity 6: Alliteration using plastic animals. Have your child choose one and ask them to make up a name using alliteration. Demonstrate first and help, where necessary ('Tiny Timmy Turtle', 'Shiny Shimmery Shark').



Activity 7: Onset and rime blending and segmenting using counters. Say a word to your child ('bat'). Have them sound out the onset (/b/) and rime (/at/) using a counter for each sound (/b/ - /at/). Repeat with a rhyming word ('cat'). Remember, there is no written word in front of them – only sounds.



Activity 8: Phoneme blending and segmenting using counters. Say a word to your child ('sit') and ask them to sound it out using a counter for each sound (/s/ - /i/ - /t/). Ask your child to march/stomp out each sound. This time the word is broken down into its smallest phonemes (sound units). Remember, again, that there is no written word in front of them – only sounds.

Phonemic awareness is the most advanced level of phonological awareness and the key that unlocks reading. At this level, children need practise adding, deleting, changing and substituting the individual sounds in a word without seeing any letters or words.

There are many more activities and ideas to develop phonological and phonemic awareness skills. It's worthwhile doing research on this vital topic using a platform such as YouTube.

Raising Readers
(www.raisingreaders.co.za) sells a phonological awareness kit with manipulatives and instructions and runs parent workshops on this topic. For further information, email marian@raisingreaders.co.za.

'Phonemic awareness is the most advanced level of phonological awareness and the key that unlocks reading.'



New ADvTECH school offering set to revolutionise online education

Opening its virtual doors to learners from Grade R to Grade 9, from January 2021, ADvTECH's new online offering, Evolve Online School (Evolve), will change the face of online schooling in South Africa.

'In this rapidly changing society, the one-size-fits-all method of teaching no longer makes any sense,' says principal Colin Northmore. 'Evolve starts by answering the question: how can we make learning an adventure for each child?'

Evolve combines a user-experience focus with a trendsetting curriculum mapping system, developed at MIT, to personalise each child's learning experience. Using the latest research, each child's learning journey will be designed based on exclusive subject and skill maps.

Students will be placed within subjects according to their abilities, letting them progress faster where they're gifted and work at a more deliberate pace to master content they find more challenging. The result is that each student's learning experience is tailored to their specific needs and they're encouraged to grow at a pace that suits their ability and enthusiasm.

'There'll be a strong focus on foundational, social and emotional learning skills. Our team of life coaches will focus exclusively on these skills. Our children are growing up in a world very different from the one in which



we grew up. Things that we, as adults, deal with and take in our stride, they're already facing at a very young age. Our life coaches will play a very important role in teaching students how to deal with issues such as stress and anxiety, and help them develop coping mechanisms, resilience and a growth mindset,' adds Northmore.

Evolve will make use of the following:

- **Diagnostic testing** to determine the exact level of proficiency of a student before

placement and during the educational journey.

- **Asynchronous learning** so that learners can move through content at their own pace and according to their own proficiency. Students will also have direct access to their teachers, who'll facilitate extra activation classes.
- **Synchronous learning**, where our students will also be able to attend live interactive classes, making this a true online school.
- **Socialisation opportunities** with academies, studios and day camps monthly so that students can meet other 'Evolvers' and get green time to balance their screen time.

Now enrolling for 2021.

The school will cater for Grades R-9 from January 2021. Grades 10-12 will be phased in from 2022. ADvTECH is Africa's largest private education provider. Its schools division includes iconic brands such as Crawford Schools, Trinityhouse and Abbotts.

Visit: www.evolveonline.co.za for more information or email: info@evolveonline.co.za.

The wellbeing assessment

How happy are your children with their homeschooling life? How happy are you? **Brett Garner** offers guidance in asking the right questions to find out how you all really feel

The prevalence of 'school at home' for much of 2020 is credited with a marked rise in the number of children entering, or contemplating, homeschooling.

For some, their better-than-expected academic performance, despite the very different mode of teaching, proved to be a positive pull. For others, a fear of Covid-19 exposure, unhappiness with rigid school policies or the need to cut back on expenses was an unwelcome push.

For those who were pushed, the change from traditional schooling to homeschooling can be traumatic for both parents and children – and, irrespective of the motivation, the change takes some getting used to.

While cognitive or academic development is likely to be quantified as part of the homeschooling programme followed, measuring a child's education-related emotional wellbeing – or happiness level – is generally left to parents. Often the answer to 'Are you okay?' or 'Are you happy' is 'I'm fine.' However, it might be that your child isn't fine, but doesn't have the words to speak up.

The secret to making this work lies in asking the right questions, both of ourselves and of our children.

Many of us need additional tools and some focused assessment time, rather than waiting for the odd cue from our children to alert us to stress or unhappiness.

Fortunately, the tools can be a simple set of questions asked almost incidentally as part of the regular lesson routine. This sample is based on work by Sam Thompson and Jody Aked, writing for the New Economic Foundation London, who encourage the use of questions as subjective indicators of wellbeing in children:

Wellbeing dimension	Example of question
Positive/Negative feelings	How much of the time during the past week were you happy/sad?
Vitality	How often during the past week have you had a lot of energy?
Optimism	You feel good about the future – Yes/No
Autonomy	You feel free to decide how to live your life – Yes/No
Relationships	There are people in your life who care about you – Yes/No

Obviously, these rather weighty-sounding questions are best asked in a more creative manner. For example, to assess a child's sense of life satisfaction, you might give them a picture of a ladder and say: 'On this ladder, standing on the top means things are great and standing on the bottom means they suck. Where are you on the ladder?'

Or try my favourite, the Hello Five (pronounced *High-Low Five*), which I often used as a teacher. Without the need for words, I would simply hold up my hand, with the number of digits extended to match my mood. One finger meant I wasn't happy, five meant things were great.

Students then responded with their own mood-matching gesture, answering the unasked question: 'How are you doing today?'

Of course, once you know where your child lies on the wellbeing – or 'happy with the way things are' scale – you can go into greater depth by asking them and yourself what you can both do to change or improve the situation.

In U2's 1980 non-hit, *11 O'Clock Tick Tock*, Bono belts out: 'We thought that we had the answers. It was the questions we had wrong.' To misquote that famous idiom, a question in time saves nine. Ask away!

Often the answer to the questions: 'Are you okay?' or 'Are you happy?' is: 'I'm fine.'



The big chat

There are at least 4,5 million porn sites on the web with 64 000 visitors per minute, writes clinical psychologist and co-founder of KLIKD.co.za, **Pam Tudin.**

What does this mean for your child?

A 2019 report reveals that 70,7% of tweens and 84,0% of teens encountered nudity or sexual content online. So while we are not trying to give it the thumbs up, most kids will discover porn and, like anything inevitable, it's easier if you plan for it.

Tips

Know where you stand on porn before you get into the discussion. We all have different values in relation to porn, but some basics prevail when it comes to the big chat.

Don't respond immediately with shock, shame or indifference (they won't buy the latter anyway).

Get real. If they're big enough to stream it, they are big enough to talk about it. This means

normalising their interest, but not normalising what they find online. Explain that there is no need for shame in relation to their curiosity, but that porn is not the real deal. Women and men don't look or act like that in real life. Talk about how these kinds of images are going to make it hard for them to have sex in the real world, because women actually like to be engaged as people, not as life support systems for vaginas! And guys don't have to perform for three hours straight

**'This means
normalising their
interest in sex, but
not normalising what
they find online'**

to be considered men. If you can help them understand how porn affects them in their lives, not just that it is sexist, you have a much higher chance of being heard.

Impart (but maybe not all on the same day) that porn is like a drug – our brains need more of it to feel less. And by 'more', we mean extremes. Then it will be hard to be aroused in the real world, by real women when the time comes. There's no fun in that.

Don't forget to throw in how important the notion of consent is in the real world.

Lastly, stay away from shaming them – even if your family values abhor porn. The teen years are hard enough without added angst.

Good luck!

Unicef.org also offers the following tips for keeping your children safe online

Use technology to protect them. Check that your child's device is running the latest software and antivirus programs, and that privacy settings are on. Keep webcams covered when not in use. For younger children, tools such as parental controls, including safe search, can help keep online experiences positive.

Be cautious of free online educational resources. Your child should never have to provide a photo or their full name to use these resources. Remember to

check the privacy settings to minimise data collection. Help your child learn to keep personal information private, especially from strangers.

Create opportunities for your child to have safe and positive online interactions with friends, family and you. Connecting with others is more important than ever at the moment and this can be an excellent opportunity for you to model kindness and empathy in your 'virtual interactions'.

Help your child recognise and avoid misinformation and age-inappropriate content that may increase anxiety about the Covid-19 virus. Many digital resources from credible organisations like UNICEF and the World Health Organisation are available for you and your child to learn about the virus together.

Spend time with your child to identify age-appropriate apps, games and other online entertainment.



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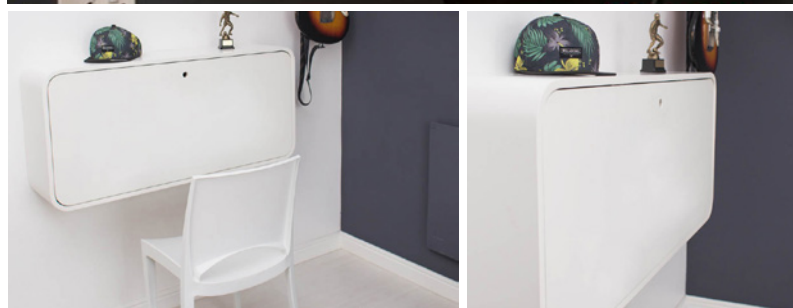
CONGRATULATIONS!

SHIRIN VAWDA, YOU'RE THE WINNER

of the ROCA Aiden Desk competition from ROCA Kids Furniture & Décor (SA Homeschooling Issue 1).
The prize sponsor will be in contact with you soon.

Thank you to everyone who entered.

**We have another fantastic competition
for you in this issue! See page 20.**



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Building better brains

What we eat and what we do affects both our brains and our bodies. We all know that, right? But do you know how certain nutrients impact on your children's learning and wellbeing, or why a hula-hoop can make you smarter?

Nutrients of knowledge

Protein. Helps build

and repair cells, enzymes and hormones. Optimises brain function and helps maintain healthy heart-brain communication.

Find it in meat, poultry, seafood, dairy, beans and peas, eggs, soy products, nuts and seeds.

Zinc. Plays a critical role in cell growth and resistance to infections. Aids short-term memory.

Find it in many meats, fish, dairy products, nuts and oysters.

Iron. Carries oxygen to the brain and is crucial to mental performance. Good for cognitive language and motor development.

Find it in meats, beans and lentils, fortified cereals and breads, dark leafy vegetables and baked potatoes.

Choline. Important for memory and other brain functions. Speeds up the creation and release of acetylcholine, a protein that carries signals between brain cells.

Find it in meat, dairy, eggs and vegetables.

**Folic acid.**

Can support improved memory, better change in cognitive function and better information processing.

Find it in liver, spinach, fortified cereals and breads.

Iodine. Essential for normal growth and the development of the brain.

Find it in iodised salt, seafood, dairy products, enriched grains and seaweed.

Vitamin D. Important for brain function.

Find it in the flesh of fatty fish, fish oils – and out in the sunshine!

B vitamins. Help produce the energy needed to develop new brain cells.

Find B6 in liver and other organ meats, fish, potatoes, starchy vegetables and fruit (not citrus). Find B12 in meat, fish, eggs and dairy.

Omega-3s. Help build cell membranes in the brain and may have anti-inflammatory and antioxidant effects that could protect brain cells.



Find them in fatty fish and fish oils, as well as in some other oils and fortified foods (check the labels).

Brain games**Imagination and creativity**

Building blocks (Imagimags, Lego, plain wooden shapes).

Collectibles (shells, coins, bottle-tops); items that can be sorted according to colour, smell, taste, shape, and feel.

Sandpit and water play.

Fine detail

Model-building, bead-threading, dot-to-dot line drawings, mazes and colouring-in all encourage mental discipline and patience – both essential to the learning process.

Memory and problem-solving

Card games such as Happy Families and Rummy require the players to recall who holds which cards.



Kim's game: Put a number of different small items (the older the child, the greater the number) on a tray. Give your child 30 seconds to memorise what's on the tray, then ask them to look away as you remove one item. Let them guess which item is missing.

Hula-hooping, balancing, climbing games and hopscotch are great fun and the focused attention they require on specific body movements strengthens the cognitive function of your child's brain.

Jigsaw puzzles.



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CHANGE YOUR
SCHOOL





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Tiles 108-Piece
Set **worth**
R1600.00

IMAGINE THE PLAY, IMAGINE THE LEARNING

Created by Cape Town-based teacher, turned homeschooling mom, Nicola Frick, Imagimags is the future of 21st century learning! These 3D magnetic building tiles are designed to inspire imaginations, while offering children endless hours of open-ended play that provides them with the cognitive and emotional skills needed for the future.

Each set of Imagimags comprises 108 pieces and is guaranteed to bring joy to your children's play throughout their childhood. With 100 tiles, 2 vehicles, 4 bases, 6 figurines and a 24 page STEAM Inspiration booklet, the possibilities for creative expression are almost limitless. As children grow their creations become more complex, further developing their spatial

awareness, emotional intelligence and creative thinking. Fast-moving vehicles, spectacularly engineered buildings, 3D animals, and beautiful mandalas are a few of the ways that Imagimags can give shape to the imaginations of all children.

Imagimags tiles are truly **BEAUTIFUL** - a rainbow of colours and luminosity that delight children daily. They are also **STRONG** - able to withstand the wildest imaginative play children can throw at them.

All of this makes them a play space favourite worth every cent.

Imagimags 3D magnetic building tiles lie in wait. They wait for children's imaginations to transform them into recognisable structures or unique creations that go far beyond what is already known. Imagine the play, imagine the learning . . .



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2. Hover the viewfinder over the code and tap the link that comes up.
3. Follow the instructions for the social media platform of your choice.



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They are the champions

Natasha Prince's uplifting story will make you smile – and possibly shed a tear or two. The heroes of this heartwarming tale are her creative and generous boys, Jordan and Tyler

While homeschooling has brought many benefits, managing my kids in Grade 9 and Grade 3 has presented challenges along the way. Fortunately, I found some solutions!

I turned one of the rooms in my home into a classroom, particularly for my younger son. Luckily, his teacher is available by phone, email and online Zoom sessions with other classmates. I also introduced a fun work schedule which included play-time, TV time, screen time and some rewards to keep them motivated.



My elder son keeps a diary and loves playing his guitar, and both my kids enjoy soft music in the background when studying. I also allowed plenty of free time for just playing or doing some arts and crafts to stimulate their creativity. But perhaps the biggest alteration to our new way of living is our commitment to making life better for others in these stressful times. This 'being part of the change' has certainly made my boys appreciate the smaller things in life.

My boys

My nine-year-old is a creative thinker and an amazing young man. He's used his own savings to buy essential goods and donated them to a homeless shelter. He goes on early-morning walks to pick up items for recycling and motivates the whole family via Zoom to keep recycling. He also decided to enter his teacher into a competition, for which he nominated her and her teaching methods through these difficult times. And his letter won!

It doesn't end there. Tyler teamed up with a local company and managed to get a whopping 500 face shields for his entire school and all the teachers and provided over 200 educational reading books for reception and foundation classes. He and his brother Jordan also gifted Inceba Projects in Bellville with a basket of baby toiletries and a bag of soft toys and diapers.

They were both involved in www.worldcleanupday.org, where my hubby and I, the boys and their friends cleaned up our neighbourhood parks. Tyler's generosity is overwhelming and his school is super-proud of him.

'I also allowed plenty of free time for just playing or doing some arts and crafts to stimulate their creativity.'



Jordan's been a big help to his younger brother, both with his schoolwork and in all the recycling

projects. He's made some cool toys from recycled items and is very creative. This is an extract from one of his poems, *Storm of Emotions*:

My world, our world has shifted radically in terms of the economy, education, livelihoods and our day-to-day-activities

My sanity has gone out of the window...

not able to move freely as that of a human.

We are faced with 'Coronavirus'. It really strips us of everything, but I'm hopeful and believe we should take time to look inside of us and be mindful.

I've been in lockdown since before our President made it official.

I feel scared, but I don't panic.

I feel like I'm in prison, but I'm not alone.

I feel the lockdown away from the rest of society, away from my grandma, friends, church and my daily activities

but I have my family with me and I'm grateful.

I feel frustrated, but I'm humble for what I have:

a house, a warm blanket, electricity, food and – most importantly – love from my family.

I feel crazy. Like I'm going crazy, but I feel comfortable to say that music is the source of my soul.



LET'S BUILD YOUR CHILD'S FUTURE TOGETHER!

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5

ways to stress less

No-one said this would be easy, but throw a pandemic, lockdown and a 'new normal' into the mix and it's no wonder we're all frazzled. Try these ideas to bring back your chill side

A

lone time. 'Ha ha!' you say. 'How on earth am I going to find time for myself?' The truth is you probably won't, which is why you have to *make* it. Most of us tend to put ourselves last, but this doesn't help us be our best selves for our families. When you schedule your daily routines, be sure to create space just for yourself – to think, dream, meditate (more of that below) and just 'be'. Even three 10-minute breaks are better than nothing. Which leads us to ...

1

2

3

4

5

Create that routine. Some are born organisers, the rest of us aren't – and that's fine. But a lack of routine means constantly scrambling for time. Sit with your family and work out what (realistically) needs to be done on a daily, weekly and monthly basis, then create a wall chart or spreadsheet. And stick to it! It can adapt as time goes by, but it's a start to taking back your life.

Resolve conflicts. There's nothing more likely to send your stress levels into the stratosphere than unresolved conflict. These days we spend much more time on top of each other, so it's only natural tensions will mount. Sit with your family and discuss how you're going to tackle this. Commit to not reacting in the heat of the moment, but rather taking 10 minutes to think about the issue, slow down and discuss calmly – with resolution, rather than revolution, in mind. Resolve to admit mistakes, recognise you might have over-reacted and commit to a solution. Lead your children by example.

Share the load. You don't have to do everything, so if you find that you do, hold a family meeting and discuss what your other family members, no matter how young, can do to lighten your load. (If they need motivating, tell them you'll be a much calmer, nicer person with their support!) This might mean letting go and being willing to accept less than perfect, but you'll be freeing up a bit of time, as well as teaching your children how to become competent adults of the future.

Just be. Meditation can be used in several ways as a part of your daily routine. It can help you build resilience to stress, a technique to get centred when you're thrown off by emotional stress, and a stress reliever to help you reverse your body's stress response and physically relax. Start by exploring different types of meditation and which will work best for you. You might also need to set your alarm for 20 minutes earlier, but it will certainly be worth your – and your family's – while.



CHAT TO US!

SA homeschoolers, we'd love to know what you think of your new online mag and what more you'd like to read in future issues.

Your **feedback is essential** in helping us put together a magazine which delivers on-point content relevant to your homeschooling experiences and support needs and **helps you navigate** your child/children's education with ease and confidence.

You are the **core** of the publication, so let's live and learn together. **Email our editor**, Shelagh Foster, at: shelagh@isikhova.co.za.

Top of the list are the techie careers that promise to be around for some time. These include cloud computing, artificial intelligence and machine learning, data science, robotics and process automation. Many of these require degrees or diplomas and it's worth noting that the biggest challenge facing the technology sector in South Africa is a lack of supply in talent with STEM (science, technology, engineering and maths) skills.

If your child is more intrigued by engineering and manufacturing, competitive positions in those fields include management roles in operations, manufacturing, maintenance, continuous improvement and projects.

Budding financiers and accountants can heave a sigh of relief, as qualified commercial tax accountants and finance managers are set to be in demand for years to come.

Agriculture and horticulture are ever-developing industries, with agricultural farm managers, engineers and engineering technologists, scientists and consultants in high demand. Equally high is the demand for doctors and qualified nurses in all fields of medicine.

If your teen is more left of field,

Skills for the future

If your teen is starting to think about what they'd like to do when they finish schooling, it might be time to turn the talk to which skills will be most needed when that day comes

they might consider that tree-fellers, winemakers (if the industry survives lockdown!), fire-fighters, divers, multimedia designers, marine biologists and biotechnologists are likely to be snapped up once they've gained the relevant qualification.

Childcare workers, nannies, daycare workers and aftercare workers are also still in high demand, but again, it's those with the right qualifications who are likely to land the job.

There is, though, another viewpoint regarding qualifications. Futurist and founder of Fluxtrends.com, Dion Chang, says: 'Disrupted businesses have complex problems to solve, which require hybrid skills with an emphasis on soft skills: communication, leadership, ownership and teamwork. The most needed, but also the most lacking, are critical thinking and problem-solving skills. Academic qualifications don't necessarily produce those skills.'

Food for thought

While we'd love to feature all the high-demand jobs, we'd run out of pages. However, the Department of Higher Education's complete list can be found here. We suggest printing it out and starting the first of many conversations about the future.





**OPPORTUNITY
AHEAD**

After marrying in March 2004 and having my children in 2008 and 2010, I was excited about what the future held. I'd always been interested in the process of learning, and researching personalities, learning styles and brain aptitudes, and couldn't wait to give my boys the best start I could. When my elder son, Aradan, was seven, I started with Jolly Phonics for reading and writing and read to my children a lot.

My homeschooling road has been both exciting and scary. Aradan's now 12 and Lorien is 10. The challenge I face daily is the

The road to SANHSA

So much legislation, so many organisations, so much fear of the wrath of the DBE! It can all be quietly terrifying. Which is why the South African National Homeschooling Association (SANHSA) could be your new best friend. Vice-Chair Natascha Yazbek shares her journey towards making sense of it all

fear that I'm not doing enough or not having them do the right things; not following the right curriculum; not making it as much fun as I could; not giving as much attention as I should. When I look at others, I fear our family might not be as conducive to learning and fear for my children's future. But the 'perfect' family dynamic, for the 'perfect' experience and the 'perfect' curriculum, is a myth. You'll never attain it. Meanwhile,

'We dreamed of a national and truly democratically elected structure that could represent the interests of home education in a way it hadn't done in the past.'

your homeschooling journey will pass you by and all your worrying will have robbed you of much delight in your family.

I now realise that my children will be fine, that the dynamics of my family are its own and that my family is the perfect family for my children to grow up in. They'll learn to deal with the imperfections and thrive where they are. I've had to learn not to be so hard on myself, not to be so critical, and just let my kids be.

I've also realised that I'm not alone in these feelings and fears.

The circle of safety

My involvement with SANHSA grew from my desire to see all homeschooling families at peace with the government and know that there are – unfortunately – some expectations, so checks and



balances need to be in place. We must find our oasis in a system geared towards a mass, one-size-fits-all educational philosophy – the very philosophy we ran from. At SANHSA, we believe that with proper deliberation, we can create a circle of safety in which everyone can function and thrive and not have to look over their shoulders for fear of persecution.

Currently, I serve as Interim Co-ordinator of the association with Phillip Doubell. Phillip is the Chairperson of the Eastern Cape Homeschooling Association (ECHSA) and I'm the Vice-Chair.

SANHSA had been a dream and a work in progress for ECHSA for at least two years. We dreamed of a national and truly democratically elected structure that could represent the interests of home education in a way it hadn't done in the past.

At the meeting with the DBE on 17 August 2020, the department made a clear call for elected

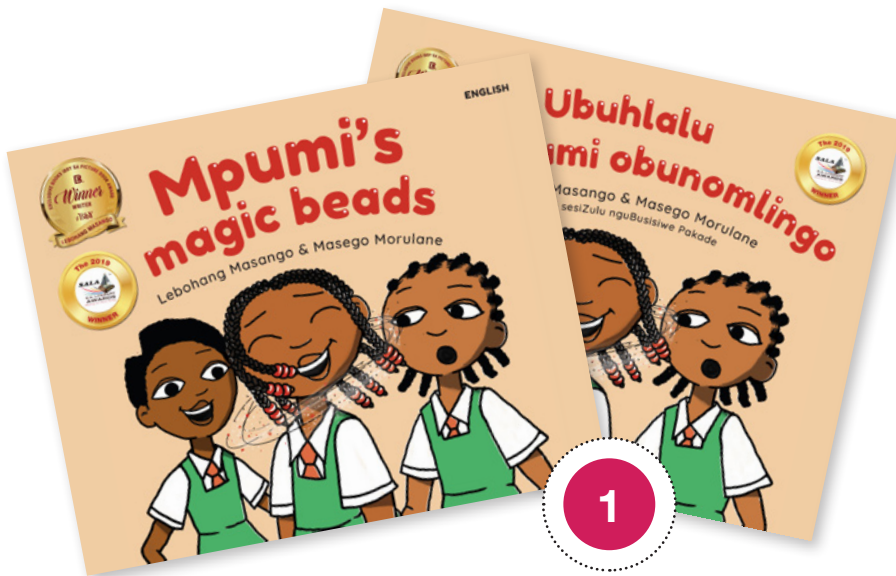


provincial representation to facilitate the process of engagement on key issues that pertain to home education in South Africa. This was the moment we'd been preparing for and in our submission to the DBE, we put forward SANHSA as this representative structure.

Although this is ECHSA's dream, it isn't ours to hold onto: it's for a homeschooling community that deserves a proper representative structure. So as associations join and the dust settles, we'll have a democratic election of the SANHSA executive consisting of representatives from the associations that have joined.

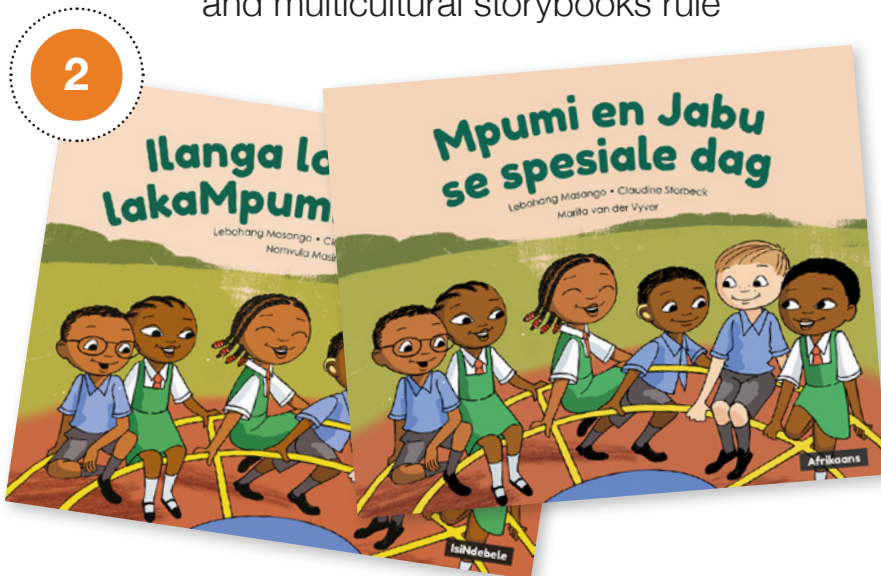
Please visit us at: www.sanhsa.wordpress.com for more information about policy, events and our members.

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Of pictures and words

Graphic novels and multilingual and multicultural storybooks rule



1. *Mpumi's Magic Beads* by Lebohang Masango and Masego Morulane (New Africa Books)

The beads jingle, jangle and sparkle. The girls giggle with glee! Mpumi and her friends discover magic in her hair and what begins as an ordinary school day in Jo'burg is suddenly full of adventure!

Mpumi's Magic Beads is a delightful story about friendship, self-esteem, discovery and beautiful hair in the big city. It follows the unexpected adventures of Mpumi, Asante and Tshiamo as they see the world around them from new heights and realise all of the fun waiting to be discovered outside their classroom. A great read for the whole family, especially children aged five to 10.

2. *Mpumi's Special Day* by Lebohang Masango and Claudine Storbeck (New Africa Books)

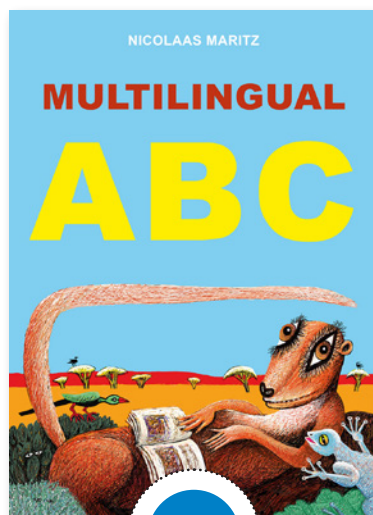
There's magic in the air as Mpumi and Jabu play. They sign and laugh, as they become friends. 'Oh, what fun!' they say. A story of friendship between a hearing girl and a deaf boy who have to learn different languages in order to communicate effectively.

These truly delightful stories are translated into English, Afrikaans, isiNdebele, Siswati, isiXhosa, isiZulu, Sepedi, Sesotho, Setswana, Tshivenda and Xitsonga.



3. *The Girl Without Sound* by Buhle Ngaba (David Philip)

As an act of restoring power and agency to young black girls in South Africa, this is a book about a voiceless girl of colour in search of a sound of her own. It reminds young readers of the power of the sounds trapped inside them. A magical story about a little girl who finds her voice after a long period of silence. Available in English, Afrikaans, isiNdebele, Siswati, isiXhosa, isiZulu, Sepedi, Sesotho, Setswana, Tshivenda and Xitsonga.



4. *Multilingual ABC* by Nicolaas Maritz (David Philip)

If there's a rainbow nation, then the current diversity of languages resembles multi-coloured confetti thrown in the air at a wedding. But not being able to speak other languages is what keeps people apart. Renowned illustrator Maritz's introduction to the animals and languages of the southern African region is glorious in both pictures and words. Children (of all ages) will have enormous fun trying to pronounce and remember the animal names in other tongues.



5. *The Kwezi Collection* by Loyiso Mkize and Clyde Beech (David Philip)

Created by South African artist Mkize, Kwezi is a classic young hero in a coming-of-age tale who tends to deal with his own insecurities by being a braggart. Whereas DC Comics heroes operate in fictional cities such as Gotham and Metropolis, the hugely popular Kwezi is based in Gold City, a stand-in for Johannesburg, South Africa.

www.facebook.com/Kwezicomicbook

All books are available at selected CNA stores and most online and local bookstores.
Prices vary according to where you shop. Happy reading!



Wall of Wisdom

‘Play is often talked about as if it were a relief from serious learning. But for children, play is serious learning. Play is really the work of childhood.’

– Fred Rogers

'Home' in on homeschooling

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